

General Knowledge

Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Gupta Empire

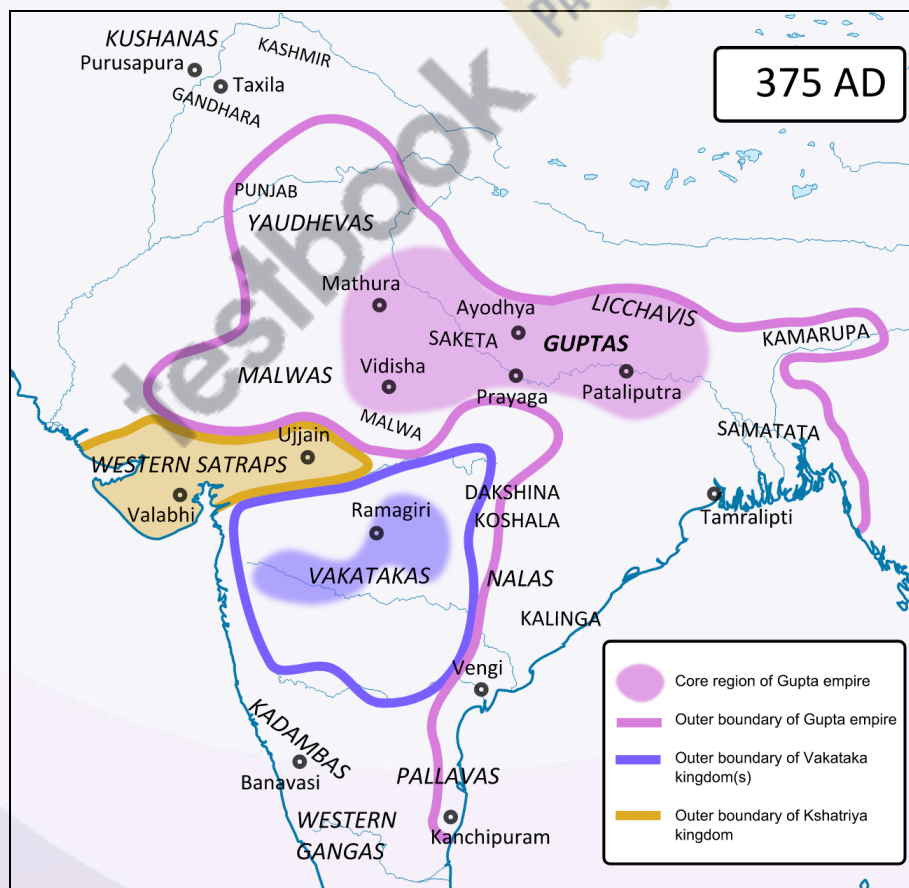


Gupta Empire

On the ruins of the Kushana empire arose a new empire, which established its sway over a good part of the former dominions of both Kushanas and the Satavahanas. This was the empire of the Guptas. Although the Gupta empire was not as large as the Mauryas, **it kept North India politically united for more than a century from A.D. 240 to 550 AD.**

The situation around 300 AD

- After the breakup of the **Maurya empire**, the Satavahanas, and the **Kushans** emerged as two large political powers. The Satavahanas acted as a stabilizing factor in the Deccan and South to which they gave political unity and economic stability.
- The Kushans performed the same role in the north. Around the **last decade of the 3rd century, both of these empires declined and the Guptas came into power and expanded their territory.**
- **Vallabhi era** is identical to the Gupta era A.D. 366.



Gupta Kings Overview:

The Gupta Empire started expanding around the early 4th century AD. They almost ruled for 200 years. **The features of Guptas are as follows:**

- Guptas were **feudatories of Kushanas**.
- They set up **powerful monarchs initially controlling the Magadha region of Bihar**. **Later, they expanded the territorial control beyond Bihar to UP and the parts of Kushanas and Satavahanas as given in the above picture.**
- The Guptas **used the iron ore reserves extensively** in central India and south Bihar.
- They also took advantage of the proximity to the areas in north India which carried on **silk trade with the Byzantine empire**.
- **They encouraged literarists, poets, and musicians.**
- **This period was marked by the development of Indian science.**
- Many artists made a very important contribution. Eg. **Kalidas, Shudrak, Varahamihir**, etc.

Ruler	Dates of Rule	Titles	Key Features
Sri Gupta	c. 240 - 280 CE	Founder of the Gupta dynasty	Established the Gupta kingdom; and laid the foundation of the future empire.
Chandragupta I	320 - 335 CE	Maharajadhiraja	Formed a matrimonial alliance with the Lichchhavis; expanded the kingdom from Ganges to Prayag .
Samudragupta	335/336 - 375 CE	Kaviraja (King of Poets)	His Prayag-Prashasti inscription details his conquests; and performed Ashvamedha sacrifice .
Chandragupta II (Vikramaditya)	376 - 413/415 CE	Simhavikrama, Vikramaditya	Conquered Malwa and Gujarat from the Shakas; patronized the Navratnas (Nine Gems).

Kumaragupta I	415 - 455 CE	Shakraditya, Mahendraditya	Performed Ashvamedha sacrifice ; Founded Nalanda University.
Skandagupta	455 - 467 CE	Vikramaditya	Repaired Sudarshan Lake ; resisted Huna invasions.
Purugupta	467 - 473 CE	-	His reign marks the decline of Gupta power after Skandagupta.
Kumaragupta II	473 - 476 CE	-	Could not resist further Huna incursions ; weakened Gupta control.
Buddhagupta	c. 476 - 495 CE	-	His reign saw the fragmentation of the empire into smaller regional powers.
Narasimhagupta	c. 495 - 530 CE	-	Fought against the Hunas under Mihirakula but could not prevent their resurgence.
Kumaragupta III	c. 530 - 540 CE	-	Struggled to maintain Gupta authority; faced internal revolts.
Vishnugupta	c. 540 - 550 CE	-	Last known ruler of the Gupta dynasty; the empire disintegrated during his reign.

Sri Gupta (240-280 AD):

- He was the **founder** of the Gupta dynasty.
- He used the **title** of '**Maharaja**'.

Points to remember:

The Poona copper inscription of Prabhavatigupta (daughter of Chandra Gupta II) described that Sri Gupta was the '**Adhiraja**' of the Gupta dynasty.

- During his reign, part of northern or central Bengal might have been the home of the Guptas.

Ghatotkach (280- 319 AD):

- He was the **son of Sri Gupta**
- He took the **title of 'Maharaja'**.
- It was a peaceful period for the Gupta empire.

Chandragupta-I (319-335 AD):

- He was the **son of Ghatotkach**.
- He took the title **Maharajadhiraja ("great king of kings")**.
- He was the first emperor of the Gupta dynasty.
- Chandragupta married the **Lichchhavi princess Kumaradevi**. (Lichchhavi is the name of an **ancient clan that was headquartered at Vaishali** in present-day Bihar during the time of **Gautama Buddha**).
- He **ruled around the regions of Ayodhya, Prayaga, and Magadha**.
- During his rule, **Guptas issued Gold coins in large quantities**. (Indo-Greeks introduced the Gold coinage and Khushanas issued the purest Gold coins)

Samudragupta (335-380 AD):

- He was the **son of Chandragupta-I**.
- He was called **Napoleon of India by historians**.
- The policy of blood and iron expanded the empire and was adopted by him.

Points to remember:

The **Allahabad Pillar inscription, a *prashasti*** (eulogy) composed by his courtier **Harishena**, credited him with **extensive military conquests**. Eg. He defeated the 4 kings of North India, Delhi, and West UP. Also, he had wars across Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, and Tamilnadu.

- He **received tribute from many kings from Assam, Sri Lanka, and Southeast Asia**.
- He **was a great poet and musician**, which can be inferred from his coins.

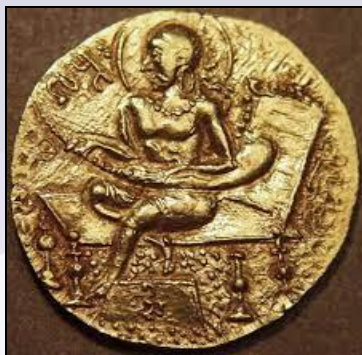


Image of Samudra Gupta playing the Veena.

- **Samudragupta performed the Ashvamedha** sacrifice to prove his imperial sovereignty, and according to his coins, remained undefeated.

Chandragupta-II (380-412 AD):

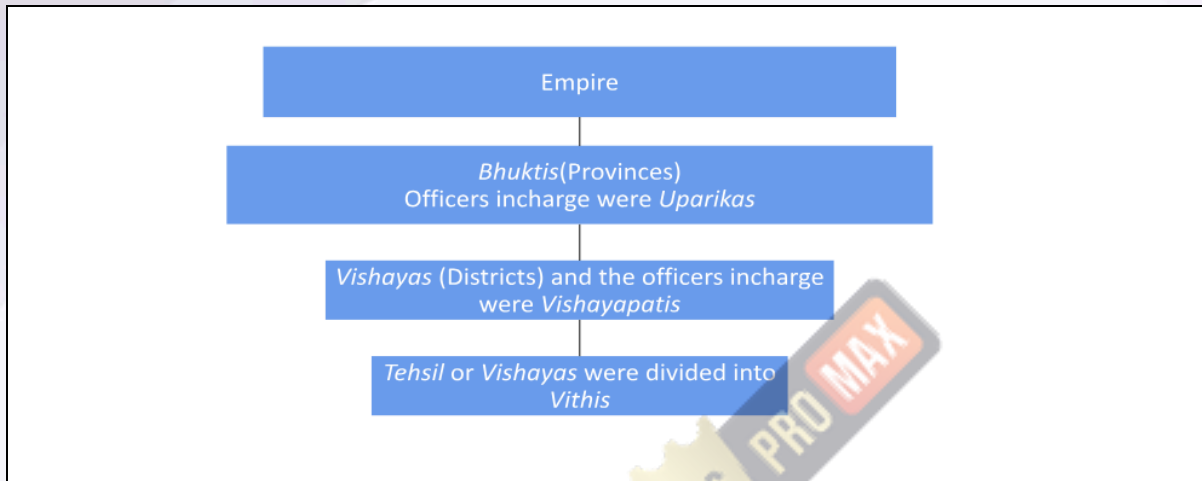
- **He was son of Samudragupta.**
- **He became additionally referred to as Vikramaditya.**
- Chandragupta II persisted in the expansionist coverage of his father Samudragupta.
- Historical proof indicates that he **defeated the Western Kshatrapas** and prolonged the Gupta empire from the **Indus River** in the west to the Bengal place in the east, and from the Himalayan foothills in the north to the **Narmada River in the south.**
- **His daughter Prabhavatigupta** changed into a queen of the southern Vakataka kingdom, and he may also have motivated the Vakataka territory at some stage in her regency.
- **Chinese pilgrim Fa-Hien**, who visited India at some stage in his reign, cautioned that he dominated over a **non-violent and wealthy kingdom.**
- He was remembered for the best patronage of learning and arts.

Kumara Gupta (415-455 AD):

- **He was the son of Chandragupta II.**
- **He was instrumental in establishing Nalanda University.**
- He was famous for the **Bhitari pillar** inscriptions near Gorakhpur.
- He was **Famous for proliferating gold coins.**
- He performed the Ashwamedha sacrifice to prove imperial sovereignty.
- There is no concrete evidence regarding his military achievements.

Gupta Administration:

- Pataliputra, Prayag, and Ujjain were the important cities in the kingdom.
- Division of empire:



- Salaries were paid in cash for the first time.
- But later cash was replaced by a land revenue system.
- The centralizing tendency found during the Mauryan period was declining due to the newly emerging feudal system. Governors played a major role in running the administration.
- The Guptas organized a system of provincial and local administration as described below:

Points to remember:

Bhuktis:

- The empire was divided into divisions called **Bhuktis**.
- It was the largest administrative unit(provinces).
- Its in-charge was named **Uparikas**.

Visayas:

- The **Bhuktis** were divided into **Vishayas**(districts).
- They were placed under the charge of **Vishayapati**.

Vithis:

- In eastern India, the **Vishayas** were divided into **Vithis** which were again divided into villages.
- **Village headmen became important in Gupta times.**

Shrenis:

- These are the guilds of artisans, merchants, and others who were governed by their laws.
- **Seals** from Vaishali and Bhita near Allahabad indicated that these guilds flourished exceedingly well in Gupta times.
- These **Shrenis** were very wealthy with surplus resources and acted as custodians and bankers of religious and other endowments.
- One of the widely referred Shrenis was of **ivory carvers of Vidisha**. This Shreni is accredited with sponsoring and financially supporting the construction of the southern gateway of the stupa at Sanchi.

“Golden age”:

- The prosperity was created under the leadership of the Gupta Empire, which covered much of the Indian subcontinent from approximately 240-550 AD. It enabled the wide pursuit of scientific and artistic endeavors.
- This period became known as the **Golden Age of India** because it was marked by extensive inventions and discoveries in science, technology, engineering, art, dialectic, literature, logic, mathematics, astronomy, religion, and philosophy. Let's see one by one.

Society During the Gupta Age:

- We have a popular account of a scholar to describe the society in the Gupta Empire:

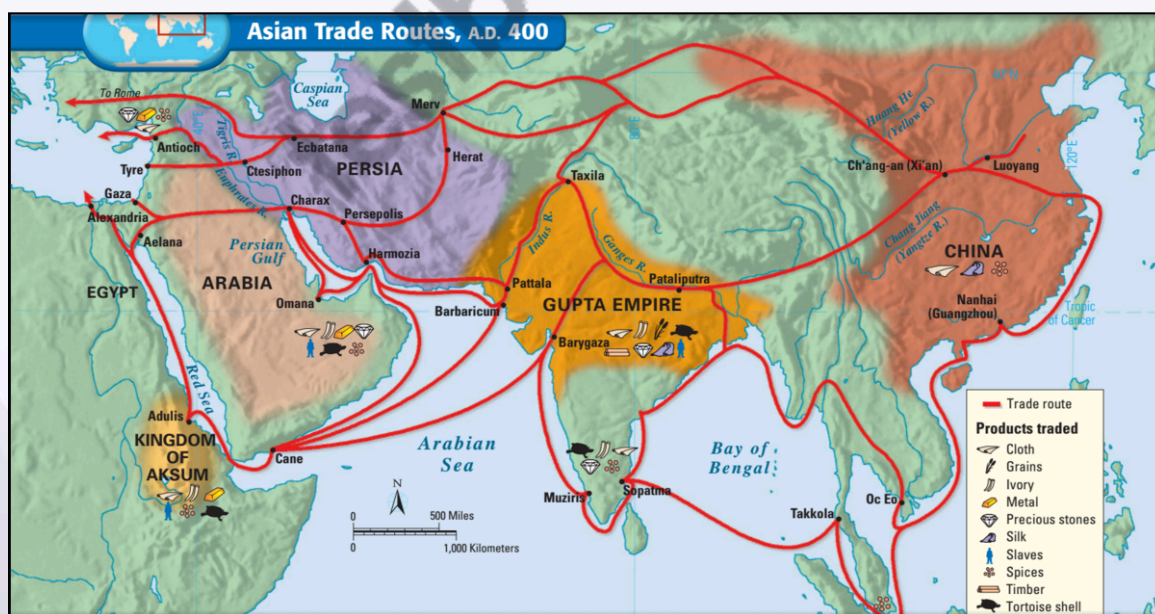
Fa-Hien (399 AD):

- He traveled from China-Gobi-Central Asia to India. His accounts mentioned the features of Indian society then.
- **The description of society:**

- **Religions** were living in peace.
- **High wealth creation** was seen during this period.
- People were **law-abiding**.
- **Land revenue tax** was there.
- **People were vegetarian**.
- There was the existence of **Caste** but **harmony** was well established.
- The condition of **outcastes/Lowest strata** of society was very bad.
- **No state interference** with individual life.
- **Punishments** were not **severe**.
- More freedom was given to people.
- There was no spy system.

Trade and Economy:

- Overseas trade was started especially in the endeavours of South Asia.
- The **shipbuilding industry** brought many profits in trade.
- **Major trade regions** were: **Suvarnabhumi**(Burma), **Yadvadipa** (Java), and **Kamboja**(Cambodia).
- **Major ports** established were: **Tamralipti, Broach, Sopara, Kalyan**, etc.
- From the Malabar coast trade towards Africa also started.
- **Trade in north India was in decline** because of floods and the attack of Hunas.



- **Types of taxes in the Gupta period**

Types of taxes	Description of the taxes
Kalpita/ Upkilt	Sales Tax and Purchase Tax
Halivakar/ Halidanda	Tax on Ploughing
Bali	An oppressive tax on people
Prataya	Toll tax
Bhog	King's share of produce
Bhoga	General Tribute
Bhag Bhag Kar	Combination of Bhog and Bhaga
Bhatta	Police Tax
Chat	Security Tax
Charasana	Grazing tax
Hiranya Tax	on special produce taken in cash
Udakabhag	Water Tax
Uparikar	Tax collected from all subjects
Teradaya	Tax on navigation
Rajju	Tax for measurement of land
Sarvarishta	Forced Tax
Bedak Bhog	Irrigation Tax
Udarnik Tax	taken from border area

Religion During the Gupta Age:

- **Brahmins became a very powerful and dominant section** during this period.
- The Brahmanas accumulated wealth on account of numerous land grants. So they claimed many privileges, which are listed in the ***Narada Smriti***, the law book of ***Narada***, a work of about the 5th century A.D.
- **Worship idols were Vishnu, Shiva, and Shakti which became popular.**

- **The Gupta kings were Vaishnavas.**
- It was not just an economic trade but also the spread of Vaishnavism, Shaivism, Buddhism, etc religious ideas across the world brought the Indian subcontinent region much closer to India. Eg. we find the spread of religion to Cambodia, Java, Burma, etc.
- **The development of a new religion called ‘Bhagavatism’ (followers of Vishnu)** became popular in a very short time.
- The features are as follows:
 - **It was based on Puran literature like Ramayana & Mahabharata.**
 - Salvation can be achieved through doing fast, pilgrimage, conveying stories to masses, etc.
 - **Bhagvatgeeta holds the base of Bhagavatam.**
 - *Bhagavatism* propagated the idea of *Avtarvaad* strongly. **Avtarvaad was defined as incarnations of deities sent to earth to restore the social order. Eg. Krishna as an incarnation of Vishnu, etc.**

Science and Technology During the Gupta Age:

Aryabhatt:

- He gave the astronomical theory about “**the earth revolving around the Sun**” for the first time.
- **He invented zero** in mathematics.
- He invented **the decimal system**.

Varahamihira:

- He had a great contribution to Astrology. Eg. **Panchasiddhantika (505 AD)**
 - **Panchasiddhantika (505 AD):**
 - The work of five earlier astronomical observers was summarized by Varahamihir namely the *Surya Siddhanta*, *Romaka Siddhanta*, *Paulisa Siddhanta*, *Vasishtha Siddhanta*, and *Paitamaha Siddhanta* in **Panchasiddhantika**.
 - It talks about the Sun, its rotation, and the planet orbits around it.
- In the field of Astronomy, a book called **Romaka Siddhanta** was compiled. It was **influenced by Greek ideas**, as can be inferred from its name.

Architecture:

- The Gupta period was the Golden period of architecture. Here are some highlights of the architectural work:

Caves:

- The finest examples were the caves of **Ajantha and Ellora**.
- Themes were based on Buddhism for Ajantha and Buddhism, Jainism, and Brahmanism for Ellora Caves.
- Beautiful expressions of **Mural paintings** were found at these sites.



Sculptures:

- **Sultanganj Buddha** (a Gupta-Pala transitional period sculpture) statue of 7.5 ft. as given below.
- It was made up of **cream-coloured sandstone and used metal**.



Temple architecture:

- The Gupta period marked the **beginning of temple architecture**.
- Based on the regions 3 basic styles of architecture were found as given below:

Nagara style architecture(North)	
Dravidian style architecture(South)	
Vesera style architecture(Mixed)	

Architecture style	Features and examples
Nagara school	• Originated in North India.

	• Panchayatan style, upraised platform, Shikhara, etc. are some features. • Eg. Dashavatara temple, Deogarh, UP.
Dravidian school	• Originated in South India • Flourished under the Chola empire. • High Boundary walls, Water tank, Vimana, etc. are some unique features of it. • Eg. Brihadeshwara Temple, Thanjavur (2nd century AD)
Vesara school	• It's a mix of features of Nagara and Dravidian schools. • Originated later in the mid-7th century. • Chalukyas, Rashtrakutas, and Hoysala dynasties were the main patronage of this school. • Eg. Ladkhan temple, Aihole

Pillar art:

- Examples: **Mehrauli Iron pillar by Chandragupta-II**, Allahabad pillar inscriptions by **Samudragupta**, etc.

The Mehrauli Iron Pillar:

- It was made during the **Gupta period** but it was later moved to Delhi by **Firoz Shah Tughlaq**.
- It has **inscriptions of Chandragupta-II or Vikramaditya**. It talks about the conquest and achievements of the king.
- **The below picture shows it:**



Allahabad pillar:

- Inscriptions of Samudragupta were found.
- It mentioned **Samudragupta as Napoleon of India.**
- It mentioned that he had the **largest number of gold coins.**

Literature:

- **Revival of Puranas:** Ramayana and Mahabharata were revived.
- The Gupta period was remarkably noted for **Secular Literature.**
- In this period **thirteen plays were written by Bhasa.**
- The **Mrichchhakatika** or 'the little clay Cart' was written by **Shudraka**, It's a story of urban life that dealt with the **love story** of the beautiful daughter of a courtesan named **Vasantsena and Charudatta.**
- The Gupta period also saw the **development of Sanskrit grammar** based on **Panini and Patanjali.**
- This period was particularly memorable for the compilation of the **Amarakosha** by **Amarsimha**, who was a luminary in the court of Chandra Gupta-II.

Authors	Literature
Kalidasa (4th-5th century)	• <i>Raghuvansham</i> • <i>Kumarasambhava</i> • <i>Abhigyan Shakuntalam</i> • <i>Meghdoot</i>
Vishakhadatta (4th-5th century)	• <i>Mudrarakshasa</i>
Shudrak (4th-5th century)	• <i>Mrichhakatikam</i>

Numismatic art:

- The Gupta Empire issued large-scale **Gold coins called 'Dinars'**.
- **Kumar Devi coins: King and wife carving on the coins by Chandragupta-I**
- **King playing the Veena by Samudragupta as given below:**
- Other forms of coins were: **Imprints of a Lion laying down, Ashwamedha**, etc.



Decline of the Gupta Empire:

There were various reasons behind the decline of the Gupta kingdom. Let's see one by one:

- **Later rulers were too weak** to control the empire.

- **Division of empire:** Governors became more powerful and started behaving like rulers taking advantage of the weak rulers of Gupta.
- **The attack of Hunas from the North-West frontier** weakened the Gupta empire:
 - The Gupta prince **Skandagupta** (Son of Kumaragupta ruled from 455 to 467 AD and fought bravely against the earliest Huns' invasion.
 - However, his successors proved to be weak and could not check the Huns' invasion.
 - Large parts of **western and northern India came under Huns** in the middle 5th century.



- **Land revenue system** adopted by Guptas: It made governors of provinces stronger. Eg. Aulikara dynasty, Vardhana dynasty, etc.
- **Contemporary kingdoms** created after the breaking up of the Gupta empire as follows:
 - Pushyabhutis at Thanesar
 - Chandellas near Bihar
 - Pratiharas at Kannauj
 - Chauhans at Rajasthan
 - Tomars at Delhi
 - Rashtrakutas at Deccan
 - Palas near Odisha

Impact of Gupta rule on society:

Education:

- Two universities emerged, especially Nalanda at Bihar and Taxila University at Peshawar.

Nalanda University:

- It emerged during the Kumaragupta rule(415-455 AD) but became popular during the Harshavardhana period and Pala kings.
- Major teachings were related to Mahayana Buddhism.
- Subjects like Vedas, fine arts, grammar, philosophy, logic, and medicine were also taught here.
- This university deeply influenced Tibetan Buddhism.

Fa-Hien description:

- He visited Nalanda University.
- Recorded the details of Nalanda University in his account.
- Eg. He mentioned exam patterns, teachers, scholars, books, etc.
- Scholars: Aryabhatta, Nagarjuna, etc. produced by this organization.

Taxila University:

- It existed since the 5th century BC but got popular in the Gupta period.
- Subjects like political science, Hunting, Medicine, Law, and military tactics were taught here.
- Notable teachers and alumni were Chanakya, Charaka, Panini, Jivaka, Pasenajit, etc.

Class-Caste division:

The societal division was there according to Fa-Hien's account. Some more features were:

- The Varna system prevailed during the Gupta times.
- Brahmins became the dominant section.
- The caste-based division was accepted based on birth and not occupation.
- Caste conversion was not allowed.

- **Inter-caste marriages were declining.**
- The **position of Shudras in this period:** They were now permitted to listen to the Ramayana, Mahabharata, and Puranas. They could worship a new God called Krishna. They were also allowed to perform certain domestic rites.
- There was a class called **Chandalas** who lived outside the main city and were considered untouchables and used to do lowry work.
- Despite the discrimination in society, **people used to live in harmony.**

Role of women:

- The **position of women had not improved in society. It was the biggest criticism of this period.**
- **The first example of the immolation of a widow after the death of her husband appeared in Gupta times in A.D. 510.** However, some post-Gupta law books held that a woman can remarry if her husband is dead, destroyed, impotent, etc.
- **Polygamy** was allowed.
- There was an existence of the **Devadasi** system.
- **Sati system started prevailing in society.**
- **Widow remarriage was included in the law.**
- **Education was denied to women.**
- **Women of higher varnas** did not have access to independent sources of livelihood in pre-Gupta and Gupta times. The fact that women of the two lower varnas were free to earn their livelihood gave them considerable freedom which was denied to the women of the upper two varnas.
- Women's opinions were not taken into consideration for discussing village issues or family issues.
- **Marriage systems like Daive, and Gandharva** destroyed the lives of young girls.
 - **Daive:** Daughters married priests.
 - **Gandharva-** Man can forcefully capture girls and marry them.

Money and wealth:

The Gupta period was considered a period of wealth creation.

The reasons were as follows:

- **Employment diversity** apart from agriculture and weaving created new ways of earning money.
- **Metalworks** started in a boom because of the demands of creating new weapons and other defense works. **It brought a lot of investments directly from the treasury of the kingdom.**
- Creation of **Gold coins** which were in high demand in the outside markets. It resulted in more money in the hands of the people.
- **Trade routes were evolved.** Eg. land and sea routes trade increased which made the Gupta Empire rich.
- **The promotion of art and architecture** by merchants and kings led to the evolution of artistic professions. Artists started earning a respectable amount of money.
- **There was a development of new industries like Shipbuilding, textile, weapon manufacturing, etc. which attracted investments.**
- Religious functionaries were granted **land, free of tax, forever, and they were authorized to collect from the peasants** all the taxes which could have otherwise gone to the emperor.
- **Religious grants: Agrahara** grants were meant for the **Brahmanas** which were meant to be **perpetual, hereditary, and tax-free, accompanied by the assignment of all land revenue.**